

Wednesday, 23 September 2026.

Your daily radio show prep — three top news stories, forward-looking showbiz, sport that matters this week, talkback prompts, and day notes for today and tomorrow. Built fresh every weekday, ready by 3pm for tomorrow's show.

00 — WEATHER

Tomorrow's forecast

LONDON

Overcast

22° 16°

BIRMINGHAM

Rain

20° 13°

MANCHESTER

Rain

18° 12°

GLASGOW

Rain

17° 11°

01 — NEWS

Today's top stories

- 1 Counter-terror police say they've disrupted a plot targeting Manchester's Jewish community, leading to two arrests.**

The arrests were made on Sunday in Manchester. Police are investigating the full extent of the alleged plot.

CRIME · UK

- 2 Martha's Rule is now being rolled out at every A&E department across England, giving patients and families more power.**

The new rule means patients, or their families, can demand a second opinion if they feel their concerns about care aren't being heard. It's named after 13-year-old Martha Mills, whose family's worries were overlooked before her death.

HEALTH · UK

- 3 Sir Jim Ratcliffe's Ineos has suspended production at key UK plants, blaming soaring gas prices.**

The company says natural gas in the UK is now twelve times more expensive than in the US. This move raises concerns about the impact of energy costs on British industry.

BUSINESS · UK

- 4 Prime Minister Burnham is in New York and expects to find 'common ground' with Donald Trump in their first meeting.**

Mr Burnham is also set to deliver a speech to the UN General Assembly, with a focus expected to be on artificial intelligence. It's a significant moment on the international stage.

POLITICS · UK

- 5 A father has admitted causing the death of his two-year-old son, who fell from a hotel window in Cyprus.**

The tragic incident occurred in July, and a Paphos court heard the father's admission. It's a heartbreaking story.

CRIME · UK

What's coming up

- 1 Apple Music is set to open its very own concert venue right here in Battersea, London.**
The tech giant has built a dedicated concert hall, but insists it's not looking to compete with smaller, independent venues. It'll be interesting to see what acts they bring in.
| ON AIR – What kind of acts do you think Apple Music will attract to their new venue?
MUSIC · COMING UP
- 2 Sir Sean Connery's family has announced plans for a new filmmaking centre in Edinburgh, named after the legendary actor.**
The James Bond star, who started out as a milkman in the Scottish capital, will be honoured with this new facility. It's a lovely tribute to his legacy.
| ON AIR – What's your favourite Sean Connery film, and why?
FILM · COMING UP
- 3 Burberry closed London Fashion Week 2026 with its signature check print and a star-studded front row.**
As Fashion Week wraps up, we're getting a clearer picture of the biggest trends for our wardrobes next year. It sounds like a glamorous end to the event.
| ON AIR – Do you follow fashion trends, or do you stick to your own style?
FASHION · THIS WEEK
- 4 Queen drummer Roger Taylor has revealed how the band perfected their trademark harmonies in a rather unusual spot.**
He says they used to practice their singing in a cave on a beach in Cornwall. Imagine stumbling across that rehearsal!
| ON AIR – If you could witness any band rehearsing, who would it be and where?
MUSIC · PAST
- 5 Jay-Z's long-awaited UK show saw some incredible surprise guests, including Lauryn Hill, Wyclef, and Giggs.**
The US rapper rolled back the years for over two hours at the first of his two London shows. Sounds like an unforgettable night for fans!
| ON AIR – Who is the best surprise guest you've ever seen at a concert?
MUSIC · THIS WEEK

On the schedule

- 1** **England fast bowler Mark Wood has announced his immediate retirement from international cricket.**
Wood has been a key part of the England setup for years, known for his incredible pace. It marks the end of an era for the fast bowler.

ON AIR – How do you think Mark Wood will be remembered in English cricket?
CRICKET · UK

- 2** **Mikel Arteta has agreed an improved new contract with Premier League champions Arsenal.**
This news will be a boost for Gunners fans, securing the manager who led them to the title. It shows the club's commitment to their long-term vision.

ON AIR – Do you think Arteta is the right man to keep Arsenal at the top?
FOOTBALL · UK

- 3** **Great Britain has been beaten by a strong Czech Republic side in the Billie Jean King Cup quarter-finals.**
Sonay Kartal and Katie Boulter both lost their singles matches, meaning GB couldn't progress further. It's a tough exit for the team.

ON AIR – What do you think GB needs to do to compete more consistently in team tennis events?
TENNIS · UK

- 4** **Sachindu Colombage had a dream debut for Sri Lanka, taking three key wickets against England in the first ODI.**

He removed Joe Root, Jos Buttler, and Jamie Overton, finishing with figures of 3-44 at Chester-le-Street. What an introduction to international cricket!

ON AIR – What's the most impressive sporting debut you've ever seen?
CRICKET · UK

- 5** **Henry Pollock turned down significantly more money to stay at Northampton Saints, according to his adviser Eddie Hearn.**

Pollock's extension will still earn him over £400,000 a year, but he chose loyalty over rival offers. A big decision in the world of rugby.

ON AIR – How important is loyalty in professional sport, compared to financial gain?
RUGBY · UK

Quick hits

- 1 A new study suggests that looking at pictures of cute animals can actually boost your productivity.**
Researchers found that participants performed tasks more carefully after viewing images of puppies and kittens. So next time you need a pick-me-up at work, you know what to do!
- 2 The humble 'packed lunch' is experiencing a gourmet makeover across the country.**
Forget soggy sandwiches; people are now crafting elaborate, healthy, and Instagram-worthy meals to take to work or school. Bento boxes are apparently all the rage!
- 3 Experts are advising us to embrace the joy of 'window gazing' for improved mental well-being.**
Taking a few moments each day to simply look out of a window and observe the world can be surprisingly calming and a great way to de-stress. Perfect for a rainy afternoon!
- 4 A fascinating trend sees more people learning the ancient craft of 'basket weaving'.**
It's a wonderfully tactile and meditative hobby, creating beautiful, functional items from natural materials. Plus, you get a lovely basket at the end of it!
- 5 Scientists have discovered that listening to the sound of 'distant church bells' can evoke feelings of nostalgia and peace.**
The unique acoustics and historical resonance of bell chimes apparently tap into our collective memory, offering a moment of quiet reflection.
- 6 The delightful practice of 'swapping homemade jams and preserves' is becoming a popular community activity.**
It's a lovely way to share culinary skills, reduce food waste, and enjoy a taste of local produce. Who needs a shop when you have a neighbour with a blackberry bush?
- 7 New research highlights the benefits of 'walking barefoot on natural surfaces' for overall health.**
Apparently, it can improve balance, strengthen foot muscles, and even reduce inflammation. Just be sure to watch out for any stray pebbles!

05 – TALKBACK

For the phone lines

OUR SURVEY SAID

Q Our survey said that over 70% of us admit to secretly 'doing' what when we're trying to quickly judge if a new brand of sparkling water will be good, even if we know it's not strictly scientific? What is it?

ANSWER: GIVING THE BOTTLE A LITTLE 'SWISH AND SHAKE' TO SEE THE BUBBLES, AS IF THAT TELLS US ANYTHING!

Q Our survey said that over 65% of us admit to having a particular 'odd habit' they absolutely have to do before settling down to enjoy a lovely, new puzzle, especially if it's a big, intricate one. What is it?

ANSWER: CAREFULLY TURNING ALL THE EDGE PIECES RIGHT-SIDE UP FIRST, EVEN IF IT TAKES AGES!

TALK TOPIC

- You know how sometimes a 'particular smell' just instantly transports you back to a specific memory or moment in time, perhaps from your childhood?

What's that one smell, Tony, perhaps of freshly cut grass, a certain type of cleaning product, or even a specific dish cooking, that just takes you straight back to a happy memory? Give us a call!

- We all have that 'one small, everyday household tool' that, despite its simplicity, you genuinely couldn't imagine your home without because it's just so useful or brings you joy, don't we?

Is it a trusty old bottle opener, a perfect potato peeler, or maybe even a surprisingly effective dustpan and brush? What's your unsung hero of the utility drawer, and why is it so indispensable?

TRUE STORY OR JACKANORY – LISTENERS GUESS

FACT **Weather.** It is possible for fish to fall from the sky, a phenomenon known as 'rain of animals', often caused by waterspouts picking up marine life.

FICTION **Made up, but believable.** Lightning never strikes the same place twice; it always seeks out a new path each time it discharges.

06 – LOTTERY

Jackpots ahead

NEXT EUROMILLIONS JACKPOT

£4.3 million

Next Tuesday or Friday · estimated

NEXT NATIONAL LOTTERY JACKPOT

£4.3 million

Next Wednesday or Saturday · estimated

07 – FACTS OF THE DAY

Did you know?

- A 'group of owls' is called a parliament.
- The longest recorded flight of a chicken is 13 seconds.
- Bananas are technically berries, but strawberries are not.
- The Great Wall of China is not visible from space with the naked eye.
- The 'king of hearts' is the only king in a deck of cards without a moustache.
- Hot water freezes faster than cold water, a phenomenon known as the Mpemba effect.
- The human nose can remember 50,000 different scents.
- The first orange cultivated was green and only turned orange after being crossbred in Asia.

On this day

Day 266 of the year, 99 days left in 2026. Today Christian feast day: Adomnán; Christian feast day: Blessed Bernardyna Maria Jabłońska; Christian feast day: Cissa of Crowland (or of Northumbria); Christian feast day: Blessed Elena Duglioli. Star sign Virgo, birthstone Sapphire.

TODAY'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1959 — Jason Alexander, American actor, singer, and voice artist
- 1977 — Rachael Yamagata, American singer-songwriter and pianist
- 1945 — Paul Petersen, American actor, singer, author, and activist
- 1944 — Eric Bogle, Scottish-Australian singer-songwriter and guitarist
- 1972 — Karl Pilkington, English actor and producer
- 1976 — Robert James-Collier, English actor
- 1958 — Danielle Dax, English singer-songwriter and producer
- 1978 — Anthony Mackie, American actor

THE DAY TODAY

- 2010 — Teresa Lewis becomes the first woman to be executed by the U.S. state of Virginia since 1912, and the first woman in the state to be executed by lethal injection.
- 1950 — Korean War: The Battle of Hill 282 is the first US friendly-fire incident on British military personnel since World War II.
- 1957 — Little Rock schools integration crisis: President Dwight D. Eisenhower sends the 101st Airborne Division to Little Rock, Arkansas, and federalizes the Arkansas National Guard, ordering both to support the integration of Little Rock Central High School.

TODAY IN MUSIC

- 1967 — Seven people die, 46 people are injured, and more than 150 boats capsize when a squall hits Lake Michigan during Michigan's first coho salmon sport fishing season.
- 1957 — Little Rock schools integration crisis: President Dwight D. Eisenhower sends the 101st Airborne Division to Little Rock, Arkansas, and federalizes the Arkansas National Guard, ordering both to support the integration of Little Rock Central High School.

TODAY IN HISTORY

- 1955 — An all-white jury in Mississippi finds Roy Bryant and J. W. Milam not guilty in the torture-murder of 14-year-old African American boy Emmett Till.

- 1973 — Argentine general election: Juan Perón returns to power in Argentina.
- 2024 — Israel launches airstrikes against Hezbollah targets in Lebanon, killing more than 490 people.

A peek at tomorrow

Day 267 of the year, 98 days left in 2026. Today Armed Forces Day (Peru); Christian feast day: Anathalon (in Brescia); Christian feast day: Antonio Gonzalez; Christian feast day: Blessed Anton Martin Slomšek. Star sign Libra, birthstone Sapphire.

TOMORROW'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1946 — Pat Pocock, Welsh-English cricketer
- 1969 — Shamim Sarif, English author, director, and screenwriter
- 1962 — Ally McCoist, Scottish footballer and manager
- 1941 — Linda McCartney, American singer, photographer, and activist (died 1998)
- 1944 — Victoria Vetri, Playboy's 1967 Miss September and 1968 Playmate of the Year.
- 1942 — Gerry Marsden, English singer-songwriter and guitarist (died 2021)
- 1993 — Ben Platt, American actor, singer, and songwriter
- 1973 — Eddie George, American football player and sportscaster

THE DAY TOMORROW

- 1950 — The eastern United States is covered by a thick haze from the Chinchaga fire in western Canada.
- 2023 — NASA's OSIRIS-REx capsule containing samples from the asteroid 101955 Bennu successfully lands back on Earth.
- 1954 — The Cochabamba–Santa Cruz highway connecting western and eastern Bolivia is inaugurated.

TOMORROW IN MUSIC

- 2014 — The Mars Orbiter Mission makes India the first Asian nation to reach Mars orbit, and the first nation in the world to do so in its first attempt.
- 2009 — South African Airlink Flight 8911 crashes near Durban International Airport in Durban, South Africa, killing the captain and injuring the rest of the crew.

Coming to cinemas

SEPTEMBER 2026 • PREVIEW

FRI 25 Tron: Ares (+ IMAX)

OCTOBER 2026 • PREVIEW

FRI 16 Untitled Christopher McQuarrie thriller

FRI 23 Frankenstein (del Toro)

11 — FORWARD PLANNING • SPORT

On the sporting calendar